



(of Amerindian and Spanish descent), 30 percent are Amerindian, and 10 percent are European—mostly Spanish. Through most of its history, Mexico has been strongly agricultural (the people of this

land were among the first to cultivate crops rather than hunt and gather). Today, relatively few Mexicans are involved in agriculture; some work in industry, while over half are employed in the service sector.



#### INDUSTRY

Electronic equipment is one of Mexico's top exports to the US. In this small southern factory, components are being assembled.



#### WEAVING

Many traditional textiles are woven on backstrap looms, named for the belt support that fits around the weaver's waist.



#### MARIACHI MUSIC

Often associated with romance (the name comes from the French word for marriage), *mariachi* bands date from the 19th century. They play at weddings and parties, and ardent suitors hire them to serenade their *enamoradas* (lovers).

#### THE CULTURE OF THE HORSE

Mexican cowboys are called *charros*, and their special skills and rituals are known as *charrería*. *Charreadas* are rodeo-style events that involve impressive displays of horsemanship, and related skills like lassoing from the saddle, all performed in elaborate costume.



Today, most performing charros are wealthy ranchers.

#### FAMILY LIFE

Mexican families tend to be large and close, with grown-up children living at home.

Many women have outside jobs, and while middle-class mothers often have domestic help, poorer mothers do not.



#### THE DAY OF THE DEAD

According to ancient Amerindian belief, the dead come back to visit their loved ones on one day each year: the *Día de los Muertos*, or Day of the Dead. Despite strong efforts, the Spanish were unable to destroy this belief or the rituals associated with it, but they did give it a Catholic veneer by moving it to All Saints' Day on November 1. Here, a family group keeps a graveside vigil on that day.

